

Mining

People have been digging useful minerals from the ground for thousands of years. The earliest miners looked for pieces of flint to use as tools, and pure glittering metals such as silver and gold. Later miners extracted tin and copper from rock to make bronze, iron ore to make iron and steel, and other valuable materials such as building stone and precious gems. The coal, oil, and gas we use as fuel are also mined from the ground.

ANCIENT TECHNIQUES

Prehistoric miners dug shafts down into the ground to reach a seam (layer) of flint and then tunneled sideways along the seam to dig it out. Miners still use shafts and tunnels to dig for coal today. Other ancient mining techniques were less dangerous. They included panning for gold—a heavy metal that can be separated from river sand by rinsing it with water (below).



QUARRYING

Building stone must be cut out in blocks. In the past, quarrymen split the rock with wedges and hammers, or even explosives. But today many types of stone are sliced out with machine-operated saws studded with extra-hard minerals such as industrial diamonds.

